

Chapter

From Illness to Liberation — The Spiritual Ladder of Physical and Mental Strength



Introduction: No Liberation by Denying the Body

Many seekers on the spiritual path assume that caring for the body means getting entangled in maya, and that simply saying "I am not this body" is the doorway to liberation. In this discourse Acharya Upendra Ji challenges this belief directly. He lays out a clear sequence — **from diseased to disease-free, from disease-free to enjoyer, from enjoyer to**

siddhi, and from siddhi to liberation — and explains that the first step of this journey is a healthy body and a healthy mind.

A Sound Mind in a Sound Body

Acharya Ji begins with a well-known saying:

"If there is a strong mind, where will it reside? In a strong body. They say, 'a sound mind in a sound body.' So if the body itself is not well, the mind cannot stay well either."

And he immediately adds that this relationship runs both ways:

"Reverse is also true — if my mind is not well, the body will not stay well."

Then he explains that the body is not to be escaped, but strengthened and then risen above:

"But I have taken birth as a body. The scripture says that coming down from the Self, I have now arrived at the body. Now, while nourishing the body, I will have to step out of it again and again, slowly. **At the time of samadhi, a diseased state will not do.**"

Samadhi is the deepest state of meditation, in which the seeker's mind becomes completely still and absorbed in its own true nature.

The Four Steps

The essence of this whole discourse lies in a single sentence, which Acharya Ji repeats again and again:

"From diseased to disease-free, from disease-free to enjoyer, from enjoyer to siddhi, from siddhi to liberation. First I have to become disease-free. No one attains moksha in a diseased state."

He also makes clear that thinking of leaping straight to the end does not work:

"If you think of going directly — if you have become ill from the sins of your past lives, or from your present sins, then moksha will not happen."

The First Step: From Diseased to Disease-Free

"I Am Not This Body" — Say It in Pain

Acharya Ji questions the belief that merely repeating a thought brings liberation:

"'I am not this body, this body is mine' — people think that by this notion alone moksha happens. But someone in pain of every kind — even if just a nail has broken — when the pain comes, then say it and show me: 'I am not this body, this body is mine.'"

And then he takes it to far more serious suffering:

"And that was just about a nail. Actually, cancer in the stomach, in the lungs, in the liver — there is pain every day, every moment. It has reached the heart, a heart attack. Now say it and show me: 'I am not this body.' Then you get associated with it. First tell me honestly."

His point here is clear: when the body is in pain, the mind attaches itself to it automatically, and the sense of being separate from the body remains mere words.

"The scripture says, **first of all I must become disease-free** — from diseased to disease-free."

The Second Step: From Disease-Free to Enjoyer

What Can a Sick Person Enjoy?

Acharya Ji explains that even the enjoyment of comforts rests on health:

"Only a disease-free person can be a good enjoyer. Right? Now think about it — what enjoyment will a sick person enjoy?"

He places some familiar scenes of life before us:

"You made Shri Vidya bear fruit, you did your sadhana — fine, so you acquired big houses, bungalows, everything, but you cannot move about — will that do? All your life you toiled and toiled, so that later you would get lots of delicacies to eat. Now diabetes has come. The doctors say: no eating sweets."

"And while it is 'no sweets, no sweets,' next will come — no salt, meaning heart problems will start. Isn't this how the journey goes?"

And with a touch of humour:

"You worked hard and made such a sofa, did everything. Now the doctors say — its ego had grown too big — there is a spine problem, now you must sleep on a flat surface, no sofa or anything. **So if you are not healthy, you do not get enjoyment either.**"

The Health of the Mind Matters Just as Much

Enjoyment is not lost only to bodily illness; turmoil of the mind takes it away too:

"If you are sitting at home, you have bought a very big bungalow, and you cannot sit in it in peace — there are ailments of the mind, there is anguish of the mind — then did you truly enjoy that bungalow? No."

"So everything is there just for the sake of saying so, but in reality, as long as your **body and mind are not healthy, you will not get real enjoyment either.** All the means of enjoyment are there, but there is no real enjoyment... Real enjoyment is nothing at all, zero."

Manastaap means suffering of the mind, or mental anguish.

The Third Step: From Enjoyer to Siddhi

Enjoyment Is Not the Final Goal

Having reached enjoyment, Acharya Ji raises the next question:

"All right, someone did become an enjoyer. So can enjoyment be the final purpose of my life? All of life's pleasures have been enjoyed. Now I need to not be a normal person. **My true nature is infinite, so there are infinite powers within me.** So I should become that powerful man."

First a Pure Mind, Then Vast Thinking

But he also tells us on what foundation this desire for power should stand:

"First comes **pure feeling, a clear mind, a steady mind, a vast mind.** After that I should think of becoming big, great, magnificent."

"If I have to open a hospital, why a small one? I open a chain of hospitals. If I give discourses, why to four people? Let it reach the whole world. This is our nature. Try to become a powerful man."

What Are Siddhis?

"So become something of a siddha; attain siddhis. Siddhis means some powers. They can be physical powers too — becoming strong and capable. And what is the other kind? Becoming spiritually powerful. **Now, do not misuse the siddhis.**"

He reminds us that siddhis are nothing unfamiliar in our tradition:

"Don't you also call Hanuman Ji 'the giver of the eight siddhis and nine treasures'? Every form of God performed some miracle or other — meaning, did they have siddhis or not?"

"Whether it is vak siddhi, sankalpa siddhi, anima siddhi, laghima siddhi, garima siddhi — there are a great many siddhis. Some for becoming large, for becoming small; siddhis of entering another's body — there are infinite... flying in the air, they call it levitation. So then you should try to be the powerful man or woman."

A brief meaning of these terms:

- **Vak siddhi** — whatever one says comes true
- **Sankalpa siddhi** — accomplishing a task by resolve alone
- **Anima** — becoming extremely minute; **Laghima** — becoming extremely light; **Garima** — becoming extremely heavy
- **Parakaya pravesha** — causing one's consciousness to enter another body

No Leadership Without Strength — and Here Too, Health Comes First

Even to reach siddhi, the previous step is indispensable:

"But only if he is disease-free will he be able to become that powerful, won't he? Just think — he is a leader, but he has no strength, nothing, no voice, weak, sitting there taking medicine every day — will that do?"

Self-Protection and the Power to Resist

Acharya Ji also connects power with the need for self-protection:

"If he is spiritual, why only discourses? Then another person will do black magic on him. Is that protection needed or not? So he should have lots of siddhis."

"What were our rishis and munis like? **They had no weapons, but if they gave one curse — people were afraid to come before them.** So you should have your power, self-protection."

Power can take any form — of the body, of the spirit or of the intellect:

"You will have to be strong. Become physically powerful, or become spiritually powerful, or at least become very powerful in intellect — so that no one can take you on in your field."

And he makes the purpose of this power clear:

"The power of Mahakali comes to you, Bhairavi shakti — you should be able to terrorize others also. **Never in order to become a terrorist** — but so that no one ever takes undue advantage of you either. So the power to resist is needed, isn't it? That is why they say 'become a siddha purusha' — become very powerful in your field."

The Trap of Siddhis

Once siddhi is attained, a great danger appears, and Acharya Ji warns us about it:

"Now, after siddhis come, you may start doing people's work — and where there is healing siddhi and so on — and people start setting up their shop. From there, once again, through a merchant's attitude, people's diseases come onto them, and now this one too becomes diseased."

"But this is not acceptable, because he simply misused the siddhis."

Here **vaishya bhaav** means a merchant's mentality — turning siddhi into a means of trade and earning.

The Fourth Step: From Siddhi to Liberation

First Moksha, Then the Use of Siddhis

That is why Acharya Ji stresses the order:

"Above siddhi is liberation. So one should first enter the liberated state — we are told to first attain the state of moksha. You are not to start using siddhis right away; otherwise those siddhis will cause your downfall."

"It is said that **siddhis are like excrement — fit to be discarded**. But when you become jivanmukta, you can use them rightly."

A **jivanmukta** is one who has become liberated while still living in the body.

The Miracles of Avatars and Gurus

"Shri Krishna must have used them many times; yes, Shri Ram must have used them. Every guru, every avatar — do they have their siddhis or not, tell me first? Didn't Dnyaneshwar Mauli make that wall fly?"

"So siddhis can be used. Every single guru performed these miracles and so on. **So after becoming liberated you can do all this**. And exchange of energy will prevail."

The Illness of a Liberated Guru: The Halahala Poison

Why Do Gurus Also Appear Ill?

Here Acharya Ji explains a subtle point — illness can come even after liberation, but its nature is different:

"So in that state he may once again become ill, but now the illness that has come **will be someone else's illness — not his own.**"

"That is why you see Ramakrishna Paramahansa, who left with cancer; you see Ramana Maharshi; you see Vivekananda Ji with diabetes, or all the other gurus appear with suffering. But having first become liberated, they take on the karma of others."

"Now even from this diseased state they will be able to attain moksha; you will not be able to. Have you understood this much? Have you understood its order?"

The Liberated Guru Is Shiva

"After becoming liberated, taking people's karma upon yourself — the halahala poison will begin. **Only then will you become Shiva Ji, because the jivanmukta guru is Shiva, and Shiva is the guru.** Now he will have to take on people's halahala poison."

Halahala is the poison that emerged during the churning of the ocean, which Lord Shiva drank himself to protect the world. According to Acharya Ji, the liberated guru likewise takes the poison of people's karma upon himself.

"Now if illnesses come to him, if he can remove them, fine; if they become too many, he will have to take them — according to karma, according to his prarabdha."

The Difference Between an Ordinary Person's Illness and a Sadguru's

Finally, Acharya Ji explains the difference between the two states with a vivid picture. The ordinary person:

"The first one will writhe and writhe: 'I need medicine, I need medicine! It hurts, it hurts, do something, doctor sahab, do something!' He will run here and there — this report, that report."

And the Sadguru:

"If he is a Sadguru, it is not that he cannot take medicine or will not, but he knows because of whom it has come — **consciously he has taken the halahala poison** — so he will not cry as much. If it is found, fine; if not, that is fine too. He understands that it is prarabdha, that it is for some time."

"That is how the difference between these two states is understood."

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 A healthy body and a healthy mind rest on each other. "A sound mind in a sound body" — and the reverse is just as true.

- 2 **The order of the spiritual journey is: from diseased to disease-free, from disease-free to enjoyer, from enjoyer to siddhi, from siddhi to liberation.** One cannot reach moksha directly by skipping a step.
- 3 **Moksha is not attained in a diseased state.** In pain the mind binds itself to the body; "I am not this body" remains a mere notion.
- 4 **Without health, even enjoyment is not real.** Bungalow, delicacies, sofa — even with all of these, a sick body and a restless mind cannot truly enjoy them.
- 5 **Enjoyment is not the final goal.** Our true nature is infinite; to become powerful, with a pure, clear, steady and vast mind, is our nature.
- 6 **Power is for self-protection and resistance, not for frightening others.** Power can take any form — physical, spiritual or intellectual.
- 7 **Misusing siddhis brings downfall.** Turning them into a business brings others' diseases upon oneself; before liberation, siddhis are fit to be discarded.

8 **The illness of a liberated guru is the halahala of others' karma.** The jivanmukta guru is Shiva — he consciously takes on people's poison and peacefully accepts prarabdha.